

Warehouse Operations & Safety

Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) — Distribution Centre Staff

SOP ID: WH-SAF-2026-04 | Approved by: HSE Manager | Effective: 01 Feb 2026

CRITICAL NOTICE: All warehouse staff **MUST** read and acknowledge this SOP before commencing any floor duties. Non-compliance with safety procedures is a disciplinary offence.

1. Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)

All staff entering the active warehouse floor are required to wear the following PPE at all times:

PPE Item	Specification	Mandatory Zone
Hard Hat	EN 397 Class E (Yellow = General, Red = Supervisors)	All zones
Safety Boots	EN ISO 20345 — Steel toe cap, anti-slip sole	All zones
High-Vis Vest	Class 2 minimum — orange or lime	All zones
Safety Gloves	Cut-resistant Level D for picking operations	Picking & packing zones
Eye Protection	EN 166 safety glasses	Charging bays & hazmat areas
Ear Protection	SNR 25+ ear defenders	Forklift operational zones

2. Forklift & Powered Industrial Truck (PIT) Safety

Forklifts account for 85 fatalities and approximately 34,900 serious injuries per year in warehouse environments globally. Strict adherence to the following protocols is mandatory.

2.1 Operator Requirements

- Only certified operators (valid PIT licence on file with HR) may operate forklifts.
- Daily pre-operation inspection **MUST** be completed using Form WH-F01 before first use.
- Maximum load capacity (stamped on forklift data plate) must **NEVER** be exceeded.
- Travelling speed limit: 8 km/h in the warehouse, 5 km/h in pedestrian crossing zones.
- Forks must be lowered to 15–20 cm above the floor when travelling without a load.

2.2 Pedestrian Right-of-Way Rules

RULE: Pedestrians **ALWAYS** have right of way in designated pedestrian zones (marked by yellow floor lines). Forklift operators must come to a complete stop and make eye contact with the pedestrian before proceeding.

2.3 Battery Charging Bay Protocol

- Only charge forklifts in the designated Charging Bay (Zone C-12, north end of warehouse).
- No smoking or open flame within 6 metres of the charging bay — hydrogen gas hazard.
- Ensure charging bay ventilation fans are operational before connecting chargers.
- Never charge a damaged battery. Tag out and report to supervisor immediately.
- Charging time: standard charge cycle is 8 hours. Do not use opportunity charging unless approved.

3. Manual Handling & Ergonomics

3.1 Safe Lifting Technique

1. **Assess the load** — Check weight label. Maximum single-person lift is 25 kg. >25 kg requires team lift or mechanical aid.
2. **Position feet** — Stand close to the load, feet shoulder-width apart, one foot slightly forward for balance.
3. **Bend at the knees** — Squat down keeping your back straight — do NOT bend at the waist.
4. **Grip the load** — Use the full palm, not just fingers. Ensure grip is secure before lifting.
5. **Lift smoothly** — Push up through your legs — let your leg muscles do the work. Keep load close to your body.
6. **Avoid twisting** — To change direction, move your feet — never twist your spine while carrying a load.
7. **Lower carefully** — Bend your knees to lower the load. Do not drop or throw items onto shelves.

3.2 Ergonomic Risk Zones

The following tasks are classified as high ergonomic risk and require a 10-minute rest break after every 45 minutes of continuous activity:

- Floor-level picking (bending repeatedly below knee height)
- Overhead picking from shelves above shoulder height
- Repetitive scanning operations (>500 scans per hour)
- Packing workstation operations without anti-fatigue matting

4. Emergency Procedures

4.1 Fire Emergency

- On discovering a fire: Raise the alarm using the nearest red pull station.
- Call emergency services: dial 119 (internal) or 999 (external).
- Do NOT attempt to fight a fire unless trained and the fire is smaller than a waste bin.
- Evacuate via designated green emergency exit routes — DO NOT use elevators.
- Assemble at Muster Point A (car park, north gate) for roll call.
- Fire exits must never be blocked — report obstructions to a supervisor immediately.

4.2 Spill Response — Hazardous Materials

STOP. Do not attempt to clean a chemical spill without the correct PPE and training.

- Identify the substance using the SDS (Safety Data Sheet) binder located at each zone entrance.
- Cordon off the spill area with orange cones — minimum 3-metre radius.
- Contact the Hazmat Response Team via radio channel 4.
- Do not eat, drink, or remove PPE in the cordoned area.

5. Incident Reporting

ALL incidents — including near misses — MUST be reported within 2 hours using the digital Incident Report Form on the warehouse tablet stations (located at Zone A, C, and E entrances). Failure to report incidents is a disciplinary offence.

TIP: Near-miss reporting saves lives. Staff who proactively report near misses are protected under our No-Blame Safety Culture Policy and may be nominated for the monthly Safety Champion Award.